Prize-winning Harvard physicist Sheldon Glashow, together with physicist Paul Ginsparg, then also at Harvard, publicly disparaged string theory's lack of experimental accessibility:

In lieu of the traditional confrontation between theory and experiment, superstring theorists pursue an inner harmony, where elegance, uniqueness and beauty define truth. The theory depends for its existence upon magical coincidences, miraculous cancellations and relations among seemingly unrelated (and possibly undiscovered) fields of mathematics. Are these properties reasons to accept the reality of superstrings? Do mathematics and aesthetics supplant and transcend mere experiment?3

Elsewhere, Glashow went on to say,

Superstring theory is so ambitious that it can only be totally right, or totally wrong. The only problem is that the mathematics is so new and difficult that we won't know which for decades to come.4

And he even questioned whether string theorists should "be paid by physics departments and allowed to pervert impressionable students," warning that string theory was undermining science, much as medieval theology did during the Middle Ages.5

Richard Feynman, shortly before he died, made it clear that he did not believe that string theory was the unique cure for the problems—the pernicious infinities, in particular—be setting a harmonious merger of gravity and quantum mechanics:

My feeling has been—and I could be wrong—that there is more than one way to skin a cat. I don't think that there's only one way to get rid of the infinities. The fact that a theory gets rid of infinities is to me not a sufficient reason to believe its uniqueness.6

And Howard Georgi, Glashow's eminent Harvard colleague and collaborator, was also a vociferous string critic in the late 1980s:

If we allow ourselves to be beguiled by the siren call of the "ultimate" unification at distances so small that our experimental friends cannot help us, then we are in trouble, because we will lose that crucial process of pruning of irrelevant ideas which distinguishes physics from so many other less interesting human activities.7

As with many issues of great importance, for each of these naysayers, there is an enthusiastic supporter. Witten has said that when he learned how string theory incorporates gravity and quantum